C1 Vocabulary

Formal verbs for phrasal verbs

Swap everyday phrasal verbs for one-word formal verbs in essays, reports and professional emails.

Phrasal verbs are natural in conversation but can sound too informal in academic and business writing. Most have a one-word equivalent, often from Latin, that fits a formal register.

investigate verb

= look into

The committee will investigate the complaint.

postpone verb

= put off

The launch has been postponed until May.

tolerate verb

= put up with

The company will not tolerate late payments.

discover verb

= find out

Researchers discovered a link between sleep and memory.

establish verb

= set up

The charity was established in 2010.

reduce verb

= cut down on

We need to reduce energy use.

eliminate verb

= get rid of

The new system eliminates manual errors.

examine verb

= go over

The report examines three possible solutions.

withdraw verb

= pull out (of)

Two partners withdrew from the project.

compensate for verb

= make up for

Higher salaries cannot fully compensate for long hours.

consult verb

= talk to (an expert)

Consult your manager before signing.

increase verb

= go up

Prices increased by 4% last year.

Keep the register consistent. One formal verb in a chatty paragraph sounds odd, and so does one phrasal verb in a formal report. Decide the register before you write.

Common mistake. Keeping the particle: *investigate into* and *discuss about* are wrong. The formal verb usually takes a direct object: *investigate the problem*, *discuss the plan*.

Practice

Replace the phrasal verb with a formal verb.

1. We have to put off the meeting until next week.
2. The police are looking into the accident.
3. The government wants to cut down on plastic waste.
4. Sales went up sharply in the second quarter.
5. The firm was set up by two engineers.
6. Correct the mistake: The report discusses about the main risks.

▼ **Show answers**

1. We have to postpone the meeting until next week.
2. The police are investigating the accident.
3. The government wants to reduce plastic waste.
4. Sales increased sharply in the second quarter.
5. The firm was established by two engineers.
6. The report discusses the main risks.